

MAKING THE CASE
Priyanka Gandhi, Gaurav Gogoi (left) and Opposition leader Debabrata Saikia release Congress 'chargesheet' against Sarma, Guwahati

ANI

victories in Karnataka and Telangana, signals the seriousness of the 'Mission 2026' effort.

However, the historical parallel that should concern UDF strategists is 2010-11: the front swept local body elections even more decisively than in 2025, yet failed to translate that momentum into a commanding assembly victory. The compressed 25-day campaign window, the shortest in the history of assembly elections in Kerala, also disadvantages challengers over incumbents.

ASSAM

Here, the Congress campaign is a study in organisational haemorrhage. In the run-up to the polls, the party has lost its former state president, a sitting Lok Sabha MP, three sitting MLAs and its former vice president, all to the BJP. Against this backdrop, 43-year-old Gaurav Gogoi has been thrust into the role of electoral anchor. Appointed state president in May 2025, he is contesting his first-ever assembly election from Jorhat, with constituent Raijor Dal chief Akhil Gogoi publicly endorsing him as the Opposition's CM face.

The Congress's 'chargesheet' against the Assam CM alleges systematic corruption through illegal mining, drug trafficking and toll collection networks

The Congress has stitched together a six-party coalition, the Asom Sonmilito Morcha, and the party's bet in Upper Assam rests on the convergence of three leaders from the Ahom community: Gaurav, Akhil and Asom Jatiya Parishad chief Lurinjyoti Gogoi. Together, they hope to consolidate non-BJP votes in a region where Ahoms have traditionally been decisive in at least eight seats, though various observers argue that the delimitation exercise has significantly diluted that influence.

Equally significant is that the party has refused an alliance with Badruddin Ajmal's All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF), reversing the 2021 strategy that backfired spectacularly when the BJP branded the Congress a 'Muslim party', costing it seats across Upper Assam. The 2026 calculus is different: absorb AIUDF's Muslim vote base organically, without a formal tie-up, replicating the 2024 Lok Sabha pattern when Rakibul Hussain crushed Ajmal in Dhubri by over a million votes. But delimitation has reduced Muslim-decisive assembly seats from roughly 35 to 24, narrowing the returns. And vote-splitting remains a real risk, with AIUDF in the fray and NDA partner Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) fielding 13 Muslim candidates, including defectors from both the Congress and AIUDF.

The party's 20-point 'chargesheet' against CM Himanta Biswa Sarma, released by Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in February in Guwahati, targets what the Congress calls 'Syndicate Raj', alleging systematic corruption through illegal mining, drug trafficking corridors and toll collection networks. The campaign also hammers the BJP on the implementation of the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, unemployment and the eviction drives that allegedly displaced genuine Indian citizens. The Congress has announced candidates in 94 of 126 seats. Priyanka's appointment as chair of the screening committee, a first for a Gandhi family member in candidate selection, reflects the leadership's investment in Assam.

TAMIL NADU

The Congress was allocated 28 assembly seats in the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)-led Secular Progressive Alliance, three more than in 2021 and the largest allocation among all DMK allies, but the deal came perilously close to falling apart. It initially demanded 40-plus seats and a share in the state cabinet, invoking the 'Jharkhand formula' of coalition power-sharing. The DMK flatly rejected both demands.

The tension escalated when Praveen Chakravarthy, the Congress's data analytics head and a Rahul confidant, met actor-turned-politician Vijay of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in December 2025, triggering